

Velarion Company Intelligence

REIT Executive and Board Changes Report — September 2025

September 2025 marked a period of significant leadership transition across the REIT sector, with three companies executing strategic C-suite appointments that underscore the industry's focus on operational excellence and financial stewardship. The month's most notable development was Christian H. Hillabrant's appointment as President and CEO at Crown Castle Inc., bringing international telecommunications infrastructure expertise from his previous role at Vantage Towers AG, while both Choice Properties REIT and RLJ Lodging Trust strengthened their financial leadership with the appointments of Derek Bunker and Nikhil Bhalla to CFO positions, respectively. These appointments, coupled with Leslie D. Hale's departure from RLJ's interim financial role, reflect the sector's continued evolution as companies position themselves for growth in an increasingly complex market environment.

4 executive changes across 3 REIT companies: **3 appointments** and **1 departures**.

New Appointments

CCI — Crown Castle Inc (\$39.4B)

▲ Christian H. Hillabrant — President and CEO

Effective: August 4, 2025 | From: Vantage Towers AG

Age 59. formerly CEO and Chairman of the Management Board at Vantage Towers AG. replacing Daniel K. Schlanger (Interim CEO).

Base Salary: \$1,000,000 annually (pro-rated for 2025)

Bonus Target: 200% of base salary under 2025 EMT Annual Incentive Plan (pro-rated for 2025)

Equity: 2025 Annual RSUs: ~\$5,250,000 (40% time-based vesting over 3 years, 60% performance RSUs vesting February 19, 2028); Make-whole RSUs: ~\$7,000,000 (time-based vesting over 3 years); 2026 expected target grant value: \$10,500,000

Signing Bonus: \$800,000 cash bonus payable within 30 days of start date, subject to recoupment if voluntary termination within 12 months

Severance: Two times the sum of base salary and annual bonus, plus continued health and welfare benefits for two years

Non-Compete: Not specified

Change-in-Control: Enhanced protections referenced in severance agreement

Clawback: Make-whole bonus subject to recoupment if terminated for cause or voluntary resignation within 12 months

"Crown Castle appointed Christian Hillabrant as President and CEO with a comprehensive compensation package totaling approximately \$14 million in first-year value. The package includes \$1 million base salary, \$800,000 signing bonus, 200% bonus target, and substantial equity awards including ~\$5.25 million in annual RSUs and ~\$7 million in make-whole RSUs. Hillabrant brings over 30 years of digital infrastructure experience, most recently serving as CEO of Vantage Towers AG."

Source: 8-K announcement. Full employment agreement not yet filed.

[8-K Filing](#)

CTRE — CareTrust REIT, Inc (\$8.9B)

▲ Derek Bunker — Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer

Effective: January 1, 2026 | From: the Company

Age 37. formerly Senior Vice President of Strategy and Investor Relations at CareTrust REIT, Inc.. replacing William M. Wagner, Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer.

Base Salary: \$475,000

Bonus Target: \$700,000 short-term incentive target for 2026 based on performance metrics

Equity: \$750,000 long-term incentive target for 2026 split between time-based and performance-based equity awards

"CareTrust REIT promoted Derek Bunker, 37, from Senior VP of Strategy and Investor Relations to CFO and Treasurer effective January 1, 2026, replacing retiring William Wagner. Bunker's compensation package includes \$475,000 base salary, \$700,000 short-term incentive target, and \$750,000 long-term equity incentive target, representing approximately \$1.9 million in total target compensation. He brings extensive post-acute healthcare experience from previous roles at The Pennant Group and The Ensign Group."

Source: 8-K announcement. Full employment agreement not yet filed.

[8-K Filing](#)

RLJ — RLJ Lodging Trust (\$1.3B)

▲ Nikhil Bhalla — Senior Vice President, Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer

From: FBR Capital Markets & Co

Age 51. formerly Senior Vice President, Finance and Treasurer at Internal promotion - previously Senior Vice President, Finance and Treasurer at RLJ Lodging Trust. replacing Leslie D. Hale as interim principal financial officer.

Base Salary: \$425,000 annually, subject to annual review with potential increases only

Bonus Target: 75% of base salary annually based on performance objectives, paid by March 15 following year earned

Equity: Eligible for ongoing grants of stock options, restricted shares, restricted share units, and LTIP units in operating partnership with time-based vesting

Severance: Details referenced but not specified in provided excerpts

Non-Compete: 12 months following termination

"RLJ Lodging Trust promoted 10-year company veteran Nikhil Bhalla to CFO with a new 3+1 year employment agreement effective September 15, 2025. The package includes \$425,000 base salary, 75% target bonus opportunity (\$318,750), and ongoing equity grants, representing total annual target compensation of approximately \$744,000. Bhalla brings deep REIT and hospitality experience from his decade-long tenure at RLJ and prior roles at FBR Capital Markets and Host Hotels & Resorts."

Source: Employment agreement + 8-K announcement.

[8-K Filing](#) | [Employment Agreement](#)

Departures

RLJ — RLJ Lodging Trust (\$1.3B)

▼ Leslie D. Hale — Interim Principal Financial Officer

[8-K Filing](#)